Electoral Change and Voter Transitions in Austria.

Case study: 2019 and 2024 European Parliament Elections.

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Author Note

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Abstract

This study examines changes in electoral support in Austria between the 2019 and 2024 European Parliament elections. Using estimated voter transition rates (VTR) and regional electoral data at the federal-state level, the analysis examines voter retention and movements between the main European political groups and their corresponding Austrian parties. Using the R programming language, the analysis produces tables, graphs, and maps to visualize the results. The results indicate high estimated continuity in FPÖ support, despite its change in European political-group affiliation from ID to PfE. In contrast, the ÖVP and the Austrian Greens experienced declines in their vote shares. The estimated transition matrix also identifies movements from EPP/ÖVP towards PfE/FPÖ, S&D/SPÖ and abstention. Regional analysis shows that support changes were not uniform across Austria, with differences across the nine federal states. Overall, the analysis combines estimated voter transitions with regional electoral patterns and political discussion, drawing on existing research and Austrian sources to provide a more detailed picture of changes in Austrian electoral support between the two European Parliament elections.

Introduction

European Parliament elections offer a valuable opportunity to examine changes in electoral behaviour and the distribution of political support across the European political landscape. Voters may shift their preferences between elections as political, economic, and social conditions change, and examining these movements can provide a better understanding of how electoral support shifts between political parties over time. Each European country has distinct political, social, and electoral characteristics that can influence voting behaviour. To better understand these dynamics, researchers often evaluate European Parliament (EP) elections through the lens of the second-order elections model (Reif & Schmitt, 1980). According to this theory, voters perceive less at stake in European elections than in "first-order" national parliamentary elections. Consequently, this lower importance can alter voter motivation, leading to two distinct behavioural patterns: a notable

drop in voter turnout and an increased tendency for protest voting. Citizens may use EP elections as a lower-risk opportunity to express dissatisfaction with national governing parties or to vote more freely for smaller, more ideologically distinct, or populist parties (Reif & Schmitt, 1980). The second-order elections framework therefore highlights the importance of considering the national political context in which European Parliament elections take place.

Austria provides an interesting case in this context. The 2019 European Parliament election, held on 26 May 2019, took place under unique and highly volatile circumstances, nine days after the Ibiza Scandal erupted. The crisis began on 17 May 2019 with the release of a secretly recorded video showing Heinz-Christian Strache, the Vice-Chancellor and leader of the right-wing populist Freedom Party of Austria (FPÖ), talking to an unidentified woman posing as a Russian oligarch's niece in exchange for political backing (Lachmayer & Wieser, 2019). As a result, the coalition between the conservative center-right Austrian People's Party (ÖVP) and the FPÖ collapsed, forcing Chancellor Sebastian Kurz of the ÖVP to call for early national elections (Scharrer et al., 2026). Despite the political crisis, the ÖVP won the May 2019 European election with 34.6% of the vote, while the FPÖ received 17.2%. The Social Democratic Party of Austria (SPÖ) secured second place with 23.9% (Austrian Federal Ministry of the Interior, 2019a). The ÖVP's strong electoral performance continued in the subsequent Austrian legislative election on 29 September 2019, where it received 37.5% of the vote and later formed a new coalition government with the Greens, which received 13.9%. Meanwhile, the SPÖ dropped to 21.2%, while the FPÖ received 16.2% (Austrian Federal Ministry of the Interior, 2019b), indicating that the party remained below its previous levels of electoral support following the Ibiza scandal.

Over the next five years, the political climate reversed sharply. Following the 2019 legislative election, the ÖVP formed a coalition with the Greens in January 2020. The COVID-19 pandemic quickly tested this partnership. The Austrian government introduced some of Western Europe's strictest pandemic rules. These included four national lockdowns and a special lockdown for unvaccinated people in November 2021. Early in 2022, the government also passed a law making COVID-

19 vaccination mandatory, but it quickly canceled it as hospital and ICU (Intensive Care Unit) pressures declined (Scharrer et al., 2026). The social democratic SPÖ and liberal NEOS focused their criticism on specific measures, such as school closures. They also criticized the lack of transparency and efficiency in how a special agency (COFAG), instead of the regular state machinery, distributed financial aid to companies. The FPÖ, under Herbert Kickl, opposed strict COVID-19 policies, rejected all pandemic restrictions, branded them a dictatorship, and led massive public anti-government protests (Scharrer et al., 2026). Political tension intensified in late 2021 when Chancellor Sebastian Kurz resigned after an anti-corruption investigation (WKStA) into bribery and embezzlement. Following a short interim period under Alexander Schallenberg, Karl Nehammer took over as Chancellor (Scharrer et al., 2026).

With the outbreak of Russia’s invasion of Ukraine on 24 February 2022, Austria had to deal with increasing energy costs due to its dependency on Russian gas. To mitigate the impact on households, the government introduced electricity subsidies in October 2022 (Scharrer et al., 2026). While both coalition parties (ÖVP and Greens) and the opposition (SPÖ and NEOS) backed the EU's economic sanctions against Russia, the government ruled out any military assistance for Ukraine because of Austria’s policy of neutrality (Praprotnik, 2024). The FPÖ strongly opposed both the EU’s economic sanctions and Austria’s participation in the ESSI (European Sky Shield Initiative) and rejected Western policies on the war (Scharrer et al., 2026).

During the following years, the FPÖ gradually strengthened its political position under the leadership of Herbert Kickl (Praprotnik, 2025). The party maintained its strong opposition to the government's COVID-19 policies and increasingly presented itself as an alternative to the governing parties, expanding its support among groups strongly opposed to these measures (Scharrer et al., 2026). Its political discourse also emphasized immigration and included strong opposition to climate policies, along with socially conservative positions. At the same time, inflation, the rising cost of living, and Austria's position on the war in Ukraine became important issues in the broader political debate ahead of the 2024 European Parliament election (Praprotnik, 2025).

The changing political environment became visible in the European Parliament election held in Austria on 9 June 2024. Compared with the European Parliament election of 26 May 2019, the electoral balance changed considerably. The FPÖ emerged as the largest party with 25.4% of the vote, up from 17.2% in 2019. In contrast, the ÖVP fell from 34.6% to 24.5%, losing its position as the largest party. The SPÖ remained relatively stable, receiving 23.2% compared with 23.9% in 2019. The Greens also declined, falling from 14.1% to 11.1%, while NEOS increased its share from 8.4% to 10.1% (Austrian Federal Ministry of the Interior, 2019a, 2024a). These changes show substantial differences in the distribution of electoral support between the two European Parliament elections and provide the basis for examining the estimated voter transitions between 2019 and 2024. The FPÖ's increased electoral support was also evident in the Austrian legislative election held on 29 September 2024, three months after the European Parliament election (Austrian Federal Ministry of the Interior, 2024b).

These developments raise broader questions about electoral behaviour and political participation. To address these shifts, this study focuses on three central research questions: From which electoral categories did the FPÖ appear to gain support between the two European elections? Where did the ÖVP's electoral support shift, and to what extent was it associated with moves toward other political groups or abstention? Finally, to what extent did the SPÖ retain its electoral support between the 2019 and 2024 European Parliament elections?

To examine these questions at the European level, the analysis focuses on the European political groups to which the Austrian national parties were affiliated. Although voters cast their ballots for national political parties in European Parliament elections, elected Members of the European Parliament generally organize themselves into broader political groups according to political affiliation rather than nationality. These groups bring together national parties with broadly related political orientations and play an important role in the European Parliament's organization and political activity (European Parliament, 2024).

The Austrian People's Party (ÖVP) is affiliated with the European People's Party (EPP), which represents the Christian Democratic political tradition, while the Social Democratic Party of Austria (SPÖ) is affiliated

with the Progressive Alliance of Socialists and Democrats (S&D). NEOS is associated with Renew Europe, and the Austrian Greens with the Greens/European Free Alliance (Greens/EFA). These affiliations remained consistent across the two elections. The Freedom Party of Austria (FPÖ), however, represents a distinct case. Its representatives were associated with the Identity and Democracy (ID) group during the 2019–2024 parliamentary term, whereas following the 2024 election the party became part of the newly formed Patriots for Europe (PfE) group (European Parliament, 2024). Consequently, the ID to PfE transition used in this analysis should not be interpreted as retention within the same European Parliament political group, but rather as estimated continuity in support for the FPÖ across a change in its European-level political-group affiliation.

The main objective of this study is to estimate potential voter transitions between the 2019 and 2024 European Parliament elections in Austria. The analysis uses official election results from Austria's nine federal states and applies the Voter Transition Rates (VTR) method (Andreadis & Chadjipadelis, 2009) to estimate aggregate voter movements between European political groups and abstention. The study examines voter retention and selected shifts between major electoral categories, focusing primarily on European political groups while maintaining the underlying connection to the Austrian national parties. Since the study uses regional election results rather than data on individual voters, the estimated transitions should be interpreted as aggregate estimates and not as direct observations of individual voting behaviour. Lastly, the analysis examines regional variation in the FPÖ's electoral gains and the ÖVP's losses across Austria's nine federal states, based on official election results.

Methodology

The analysis uses official results from the 2019 and 2024 European Parliament elections in Austria, published by the Austrian Federal Ministry of the Interior **(**Austrian Federal Ministry of the Interior, 2019a, 2024a). The electoral data were organized at the level of Austria's nine federal states, which correspond to the NUTS 2 level (Eurostat, 2026).

Using the same geographical units for both elections allows comparison of electoral results from 2019 and 2024 across the country.

For data preparation, each Austrian national political party that participated in the European Parliament elections 2019 and 2024 was matched with the European Parliament political group to which it belonged. Votes for the ÖVP, SPÖ, the Greens, and NEOS were grouped under EPP, S&D, Greens/EFA, and Renew Europe, respectively. FPÖ votes were grouped under ID in 2019 and PfE in 2024, following the party's different European political-group affiliation in the two elections. Parties that were not included in the main political-group categories were combined into an "Other" (OTH) category. In 2019, this category included KPÖ and EUROPA JETZT, while in 2024 it included KPÖ and DNA. Registered voters, abstention, and invalid votes were also included as separate electoral categories.

The official election results were first organized in LibreOffice Calc, with each row representing one of Austria's nine federal states. The votes received by Austrian national parties were then aggregated by their corresponding European Parliament political groups. This process produced a common structure for the 2019 and 2024 datasets, allowing the electoral categories of the two elections to be compared in the subsequent analysis. After importing the two CSV files into R, the structure and variables of both datasets were inspected before the analysis.

For each election, the number of votes in each electoral category was divided by the total number of registered voters in the corresponding federal state. This transformed the original vote counts into proportions of the registered electorate. The resulting values included the European Parliament political groups, abstention, and invalid votes.

The Voter Transition Rates (VTR) method developed by Andreadis and Chadjipadelis (2009) was applied using the 2019 electoral proportions as the starting election and the 2024 proportions as the destination election. The number of registered voters was used to represent the size of the electorate in each federal state. The VTR algorithm was then applied across the nine regional units to estimate aggregate transition rates

between the electoral categories. A stop threshold of 0.01 was used in the estimation procedure.

The VTR analysis produced an aggregate voter-transition matrix showing the estimated transition rates from each 2019 electoral category to each 2024 category. The matrix was transformed into a long-format table to make individual transitions easier to examine and compare. For the main analysis, estimated transitions of at least 5% were retained to focus on the most substantial movements.

Two main sets of transitions were then examined. The first focused on estimated voter retention among the main political groups, including the special ID to PfE case, which represents continuity in FPÖ support. The second focused on selected movements between political groups and towards abstention. The VTR results were presented using two visualizations: a bar chart comparing estimated retention rates and an alluvial plot illustrating selected voter transitions between the 2019 and 2024 electoral categories.

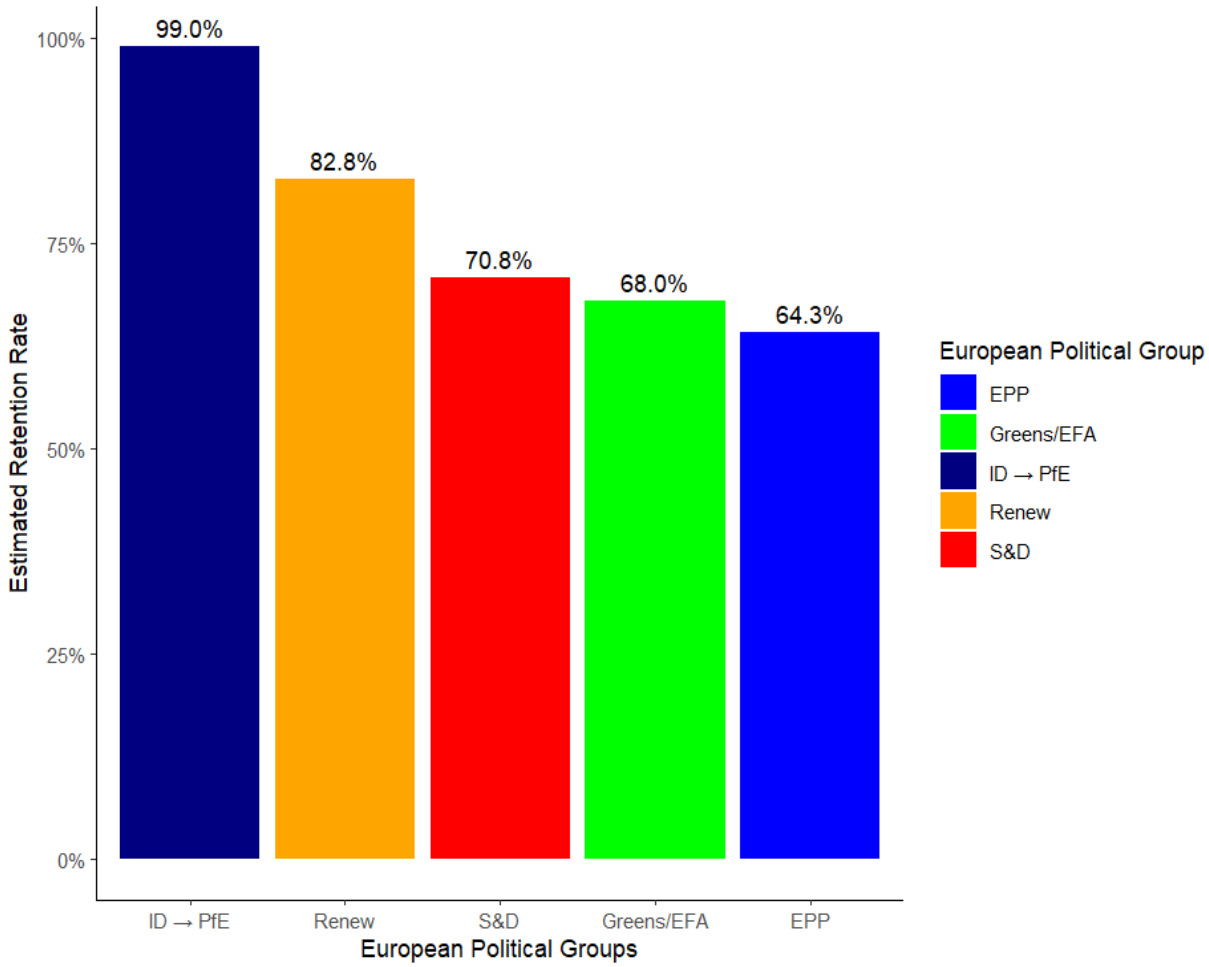
In addition to the VTR analysis, changes in the electoral support of the FPÖ and ÖVP between the 2019 and 2024 European Parliament elections were examined across Austria's nine federal states. For each party, the vote share was calculated using the valid votes in each federal state, and the change between the two elections was expressed in percentage points. These changes were then joined with geographical data for Austria's federal states and presented using maps to illustrate the regional distribution of gains and losses. Unlike the VTR estimates, these maps are based directly on the official election results and do not represent estimated voter transitions.

Analysis & Discussion

Voter Retention

The estimated voter retention rates show differences in electoral support across the main European political groups between the 2019 and 2024 European Parliament elections in Austria. Graph 1 illustrates that all five political categories had estimated retention rates above 50%. However, substantial differences can be observed between them.

Graph 1



The highest estimated continuity was observed for the FPÖ, at 99.0%, represented by the transition from Identity and Democracy (ID) in 2019 to Patriots for Europe (PfE) in 2024. This result should be interpreted differently from the other retention estimates, since ID and PfE are not the same European political group. Consequently, the result indicates a high estimated continuity of support for the FPÖ despite its change in political-group affiliation at the European level between the two elections.

Among the political groups whose affiliations remained consistent, Renew Europe had the highest estimated retention rate at 82.8%, corresponding to NEOS in Austria. S&D followed at 70.8%, representing the SPÖ, and Greens/EFA at 68.0%, representing the Austrian Greens. The EPP had the lowest estimated retention rate among the five categories, at 64.3%, connected with ÖVP. The results therefore indicate that, although more than half of the estimated electoral support remained

within each of these electoral categories, the degree of continuity differed substantially across them. These differences provide a basis for examining why the governing parties in 2019-2024, the ÖVP and the Greens, lost some of their electoral support, while the other parties had higher levels of electoral continuity.

ÖVP Electoral Support and Regional Change

From 2019 to 2024, the ÖVP and the Greens governed Austria in a coalition formed in January 2020.

In the 2019 European Parliament Elections, the ÖVP, affiliated with the center-right European People's Party (EPP), received the highest support in Austria among the political groups examined. The EPP belongs to the Christian Democratic and center-right political tradition and supports European integration and economic competitiveness. Its political priorities also include the social market economy, open and multilateral trade, and stronger protection of the EU's borders (EPP Group, n.d.). Although most of its estimated electoral support remained with the EPP between the two elections, a considerable part is estimated to have moved towards other electoral categories by 2024. This observation is also consistent with the ÖVP's decline in actual vote share from 34.6% in 2019 to 24.5% in the 2024 European Parliament election.

To examine how this decline varied geographically, Map 1 compares the change in ÖVP vote share between the 2019 and 2024 European Parliament elections across Austria's nine federal states. Unlike the VTR estimates presented, this comparison is based directly on the actual election results. The values therefore represent changes in voting share in percentage points rather than estimated voter transitions or retention rates. The color gradient represents the magnitude of the decline, with lighter shades indicating larger losses in ÖVP vote share and darker turquoise shades indicating smaller losses.

As shown in Table 1, ÖVP support declined across all nine Austrian federal states between the 2019 and 2024 European Parliament elections, although the extent of these losses varied geographically. The strongest decline was recorded in Salzburg, where the ÖVP lost 13.7 percentage points, followed by Tirol (-12.8 percentage points) and Niederösterreich (-11.1 percentage points). Oberösterreich also recorded substantial losses

(-10.2 percentage points), while the decline was smaller in Vorarlberg (-8.2 percentage points), Burgenland (-7.5 percentage points), and Vienna (-7.2 percentage points). Overall, the regional results indicate that the decline in ÖVP support was widespread across Austria rather than concentrated in specific regions.

Map 1

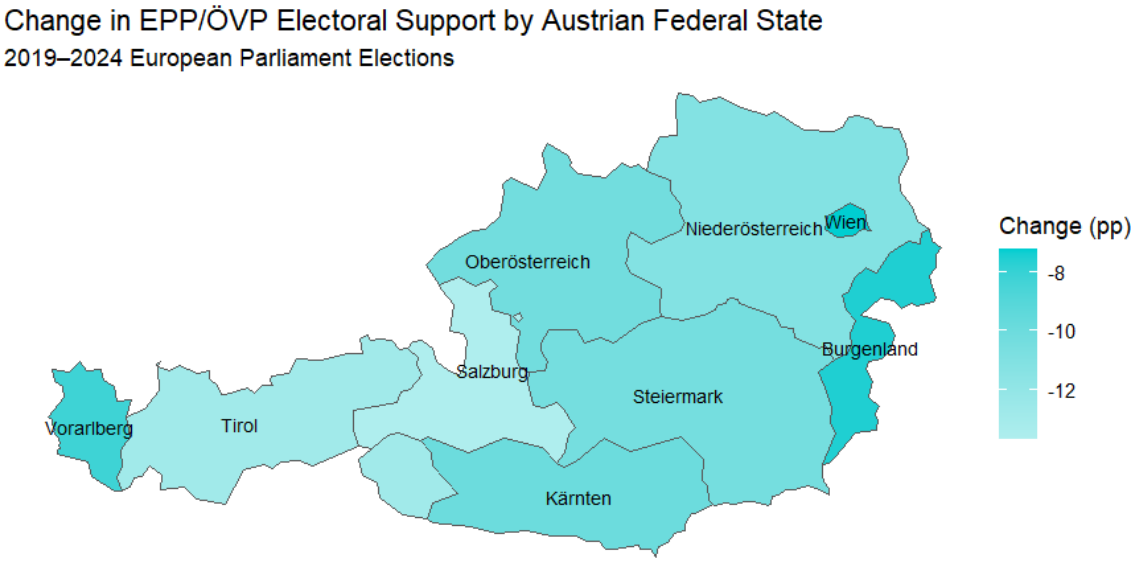


Table 1

Federal State	2019 Vote Share	2024 Vote Share	Change (pp)
Salzburg	43.1%	29.4%	-13.7
Tirol	42.6%	29.8%	-12.8
Niederösterreich	40.1%	28.9%	-11.1
Steiermark	35.7%	25.3%	-10.4
Oberösterreich	35.1%	24.9%	-10.2
Kärnten	28.9%	18.9%	-10.0
Vorarlberg	34.6%	26.5%	-8.2

Burgenland	35.4%	27.9%	-7.5
Wien	21.4%	14.2%	-7.2

ÖVP support declined amid broader political and economic dissatisfaction in Austria. Praprotnik (2025) highlights the country's second consecutive year of recession, rising unemployment, and persistently high prices. At the same time, migration and asylum became increasingly salient political issues, while climate and environmental concerns declined in importance among voters. Scharrer et al. (2026) found that 43.1% of voters identified asylum and migration as one of the most important issues on the political agenda in 2024. As a result, immigration was particularly important in the electoral competition between the ÖVP and FPÖ. Against this background, the ÖVP experienced substantial electoral losses in 2024, while the FPÖ strengthened its support across several elections. The FPÖ strongly criticized what it saw as overly lenient asylum and migration policies, while the ÖVP also adopted a more restrictive stance to prevent further voter losses to the FPÖ (Praprotnik, 2025). However, while these two parties paid considerable attention to the issue, the ÖVP initially placed comparatively less emphasis on it than in previous elections (Scharrer et al., 2026). Asylum and migration covered 14% of the FPÖ's communication campaign in 2024, particularly before the national elections, and the FPÖ cultivated widespread anti-immigration sentiment among supporters.

Inflation was also an important issue for 34.1% of voters in the subsequent national election campaign, although political parties paid comparatively little attention. Even the SPÖ, which devoted the greatest share of its campaign communication to inflation, addressed the issue in only 8.5% of its press releases (Scharrer et al., 2026). Scharrer et al. (2026) also note that the ÖVP, despite its traditional association with economic issues and its control of the finance ministry, did not take the lead on economic policy during the campaign. At the same time, the FPÖ presented a political program that appealed to voters facing financial pressures and rising costs. Praprotnik (2025) argues that the party presented its program as trustworthy to voters struggling with rising

living costs. Lastly, healthcare was another key concern, with 28.5% identifying health and care as one of the most important issues during the national election campaign. However, similarly to inflation, the issue received relatively limited attention from both political parties and the media (Scharrer et al., 2026).

Greens/EFA and the Austrian Greens

A similar pattern also appears for the Austrian Greens, affiliated with Greens/EFA. The party received 14.1% in 2019, but its share declined to 11.1% in 2024. The Greens' election campaign faced difficulties following controversies surrounding their lead candidate, Lena Schilling. These included allegations about her honesty, largely related to her private life, as well as speculation that she might join the Left group in the European Parliament after the election **(**Praprotnik, 2025). At the same time, the political agenda shifted during the 2024 electoral period. Environmental and climate issues declined in importance or were overshadowed by other concerns, while immigration became one of the most pressing issues across different electoral levels. Security and war were also widely debated in the run-up to the European Parliament election (Praprotnik, 2025).

FPÖ Electoral Support and Regional Change

In contrast to the electoral losses experienced by the ÖVP and the Greens, the FPÖ substantially increased its electoral support between the two European Parliament elections. Referring to the 2024 Austrian national election, Butzlaff (2024) argues that voting patterns differed geographically. Far-right parties such as the FPÖ received stronger support in the countryside, while the Social Democrats, Greens, and the liberal NEOS received stronger support in Austrian cities. To examine whether a similar geographical pattern appears in the European Parliament elections, we can compare regional changes in FPÖ support between 2019 and 2024 across Austria's nine federal states.

As shown in Map 2 and Table 2, the FPÖ increased its vote share across all nine Austrian federal states, although the magnitude of the increase varied geographically. Darker shades of blue represent larger increases in the FPÖ vote share. The strongest increase was recorded in Kärnten, where the FPÖ gained 11.6 percentage points, followed by Oberösterreich

(+9.7 percentage points) and Salzburg (+9.7 percentage points). In contrast, Vienna recorded the smallest increase, at 3.7 percentage points.

This variation is consistent with the urban-rural differences discussed by Butzlaff (2024). FPÖ support increased much less in urban Vienna, while neighboring federal states such as Burgenland (+7.5 percentage points) and Niederösterreich (+8.6 percentage points), both of which contain substantial rural areas, recorded much larger increases. However, these differences should be interpreted cautiously, as the analysis is conducted at the federal-state level and does not directly distinguish between urban and rural areas.

Map 2

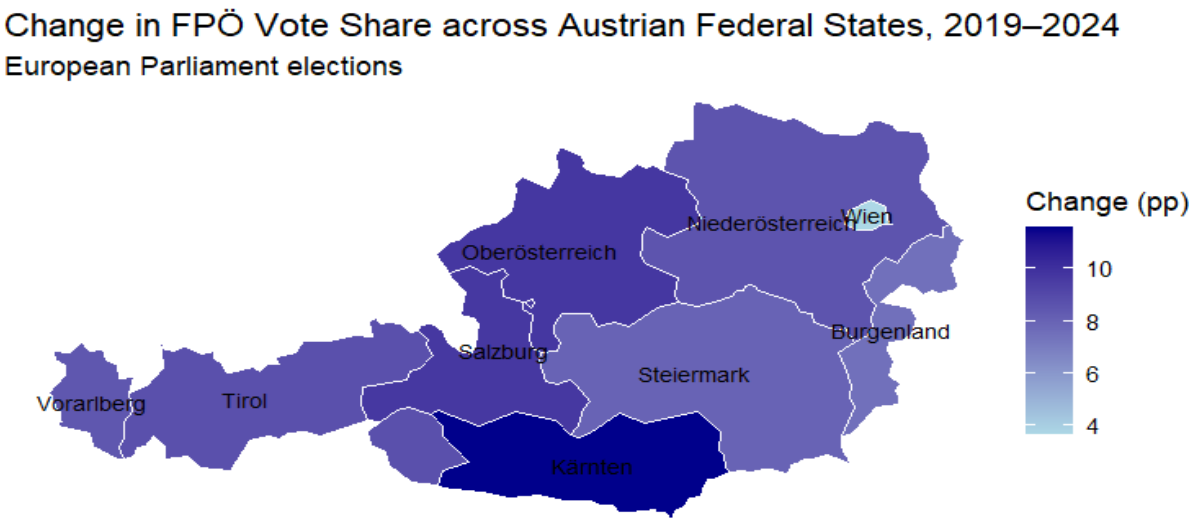


Table 2

Federal State	2019 Vote Share	2024 Vote Share	Change (pp)
Kärnten	21.6%	33.2%	11.6
Oberösterreich	18.1%	27.8%	9.7
Salzburg	14.5%	24.3%	9.7
Tirol	15.2%	23.9%	8.8
Niederösterreich	17.8%	26.4%	8.6
Vorarlberg	14.1%	22.6%	8.5
Steiermark	19.7%	27.8%	8.0
Burgenland	17.5%	25.1%	7.5
Wien	14.4%	18.1%	3.7

Estimated Voter Transitions

The differences in voter retention discussed above, and the factors associated with them, provide an initial indication of changes in electoral support between the 2019 and 2024 European Parliament elections. However, retention rates alone do not show where the electoral support that did not remain within the same political group is estimated to have moved. This is particularly relevant for the ÖVP and the Greens, which experienced declines in their actual vote shares between the two elections. To examine these movements in greater detail, Table 3 presents the full estimated voter transition matrix. The rows represent electoral categories in 2019, while the columns indicate their estimated destinations in 2024. The diagonal values represent estimated voter retention, while the remaining cells show estimated movements between electoral categories.

Table 3

	EPP24	SD24	PFE24	EFA24	REE24	OTH24	ABS24	INV24
EPP19	**64.3%**	8.2%	14.7%	0.2%	0.7%	2.8%	7.9%	0.4%
SD19	0.6%	**70.8%**	1.2%	0.3%	7.1%	3.1%	14.9%	0.1%
ID19	0.0%	0.0%	**99.0%**	0.0%	0.0%	0.0%	0.6%	0.0%
EFA19	1.0%	0.0%	3.2%	**68.0%**	3.0%	18.2%	4.4%	0.0%
REE19	1.3%	0.4%	4.0%	3.3%	**82.8%**	0.7%	3.4%	0.0%
OTH19	0.0%	97.6%	0.0%	0.0%	0.0%	0.0%	0.0%	0.0%
ABS19	0.1%	0.0%	0.6%	0.0%	0.0%	1.3%	**97.9%**	0.0%
INV19	0.0%	0.0%	0.3%	0.0%	0.0%	0.0%	0.0%	92.7%

Note: Values are model-based estimates and may not sum exactly to 100% due to the estimation procedure.

Among the main political groups, one of the largest estimated transitions was from EPP to PfE (14.7%). In the Austrian context, this corresponds to an estimated movement in electoral support from the ÖVP, affiliated with EPP in 2019, towards the FPÖ, affiliated with PfE in 2024. This is particularly relevant given the decline in ÖVP support and the simultaneous increase in FPÖ support discussed in the previous sections. The matrix also estimates that 8.2% of the electoral support associated with EPP/ÖVP in 2019 moved towards S&D/SPÖ in 2024, while 7.9% moved towards abstention.

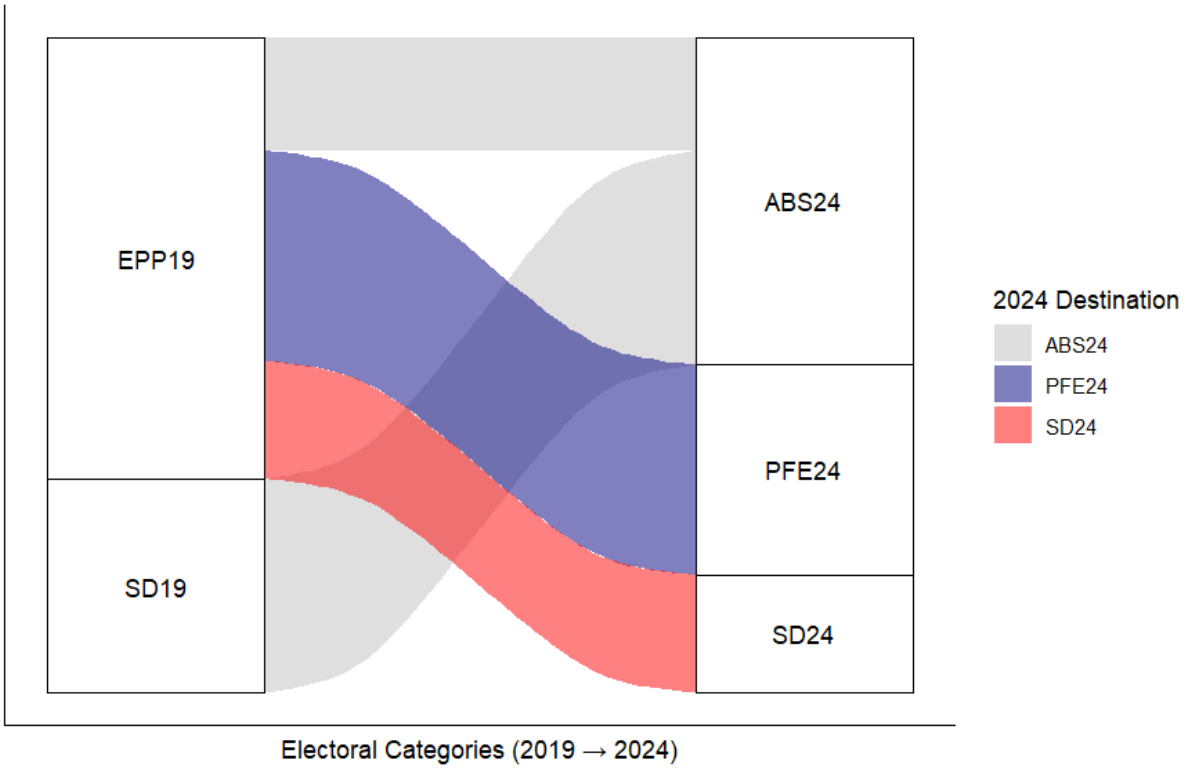
S&D also experienced notable estimated movements despite retaining most of its support. An estimated 14.9% of its 2019 support moved towards abstention, while 7.1% moved towards Renew Europe, corresponding to NEOS in Austria. For Greens/EFA, the largest estimated movement outside the same political group was towards the residual 'Other' category, at 18.2%.

The transition matrix indicates strong continuity in abstention. An estimated 97.9% of the electoral support associated with abstention in 2019 remained in the abstention category in 2024, suggesting a very high estimated persistence of abstention between the two elections. A

particularly high estimated transition also appears from the ‘Other’ category in 2019 to S&D in 2024, at 97.6%. However, the ‘Other’ category represents a residual aggregation rather than a single political party. Consequently, this estimate should not be interpreted as indicating that 97.6% of a particular party's voters moved to S&D. Instead, it reflects the estimated transition associated with the aggregated ‘Other’ category used in the model.

To examine these estimated movements in detail, four transitions were selected for further analysis. Three of these involve electoral support associated with EPP/ÖVP in 2019. The largest of these was the estimated movement towards PfE/FPÖ, at 14.7%, followed by the movement towards S&D/SPÖ, at 8.2%, and towards abstention, at 7.9%. The analysis also includes the estimated movement from S&D/SPÖ towards abstention, which reached 14.9%. The alluvial plot below visualizes these selected transitions, with the flows connecting the 2019 electoral categories to their estimated destinations in 2024. The width of each flow represents the estimated transition rate, while the colors indicate the 2024 destination: navy for PfE/FPÖ, red for S&D/SPÖ, and grey for abstention.

Graph 2



The estimated movement from EPP to PfE is particularly relevant in the broader Austrian political context. Although the VTR estimate is based on the 2019 and 2024 European Parliament elections, Butzlaff (2024) identified a similar movement from the ÖVP towards the FPÖ in the subsequent 2024 Austrian parliamentary election. He links the FPÖ's rise to several factors, including dissatisfaction with the governing parties, rural-urban divides, and the lingering political effects of the COVID-19 pandemic.

The political context of the European Parliament election is also important. According to a FORESIGHT survey, around six out of ten Austrian voters also saw the election as an opportunity to send a message about domestic politics. Immigration, security, and war were among the issues that received considerable attention during the election campaign (FORESIGHT, 2024a). These issues were particularly relevant for the competition between the ÖVP and FPÖ, especially immigration, where both parties supported restrictive policies.

Praprotnik (2025) also shows that the FPÖ increased its support across several elections in Austria during 2024. Similar shifts from the ÖVP toward the FPÖ appeared in voter-flow analyses of the regional elections in Vorarlberg and Styria. The author also discusses the difficult economic situation, including recession and high prices, as well as the increasing importance of asylum and migration in Austrian politics.

A similar pattern can be seen in the 2024 parliamentary election. FORESIGHT (2024b) estimated that 443,000 voters who had supported the ÖVP in 2019 moved towards the FPÖ in 2024. This result cannot be directly compared with the 14.7% estimated in this analysis, since it refers to a different election. However, it shows that movement from the ÖVP to the FPÖ was also identified in other Austrian elections that year.

Finally, Krings (2024) finds that attitudes towards immigration were strongly associated with FPÖ support. His analysis also considers attitudes towards European integration and economic factors. These findings provide additional context for the increase in FPÖ support, but they do not explain individual reasons why voters in the present analysis may have moved from EPP/ÖVP towards PfE/FPÖ.

Conclusion

This study examined electoral change in Austria between the 2019 and 2024 European Parliament elections, focusing on estimated voter movements between European political groups and regional changes in party support. By combining VTR estimates with regional electoral data, the analysis provides two complementary perspectives on the changes observed between the two elections.

One of the most notable findings was the FPÖ's rise. Its electoral growth between the two European elections was accompanied by a very high estimated continuity of support, represented by the transition from ID in 2019 to PfE in 2024. At the same time, the analysis indicates estimated movements towards PfE from other electoral categories, including the EPP. The regional results complement this pattern by showing that the increase in FPÖ support varied geographically. The largest increases were recorded outside Vienna, while Vienna experienced a considerably smaller increase. In contrast, the ÖVP lost support across all nine federal states, although the magnitude of these losses also varied geographically.

Overall, these findings are related to the second-order elections framework introduced at the beginning of this study. European Parliament elections provide voters an opportunity to express dissatisfaction with national governing parties or to support political alternatives. In Austria, the period between the 2019 and 2024 European elections was characterized by substantial political change, including the consequences of the Ibiza scandal, changes in government, the COVID-19 pandemic and the political debates that followed, as well as increasing attention to issues such as migration, inflation and security. The electoral changes observed in 2024 therefore occurred within a substantially different domestic political environment from that of 2019. These findings illustrate how changes within national political contexts can also be reflected in the balance of support between political groups at the European level.

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